

THE NEXT CHAPTER™

YOU'VE BUILT A SUCCESSFUL LIFE.

Now comes a surprisingly difficult question:

WHAT DO YOU WANT NEXT?

A field guide for the consequential decisions that determine what comes next.

CLARITY → DECISION → DIRECTION → ACTION

One Consequential Decision • 30 Days • Private Decision Architecture™

WHEN THE QUESTION CHANGES

There's a strange thing that can happen after you become successful.

The questions that got you here stop being the questions that matter.

Earlier in life, the questions may have been relatively straightforward: How do I build a career? How do I provide for my family? How do I grow the business? How do I earn the promotion? How do I prove myself? How do I succeed?

So you built. You achieved. You accumulated experience, relationships, responsibilities, resources, accomplishments—and probably a few scars along the way.

WHAT DO I ACTUALLY WANT NOW?

That question can be surprisingly difficult for successful people to answer. Not because you've failed. Quite the opposite. You may have more options than you've ever had before. And that can be the problem.

NOTHING HAS TO BE WRONG

You don't have to hate your job. Your business doesn't have to be failing. Your life doesn't need to be falling apart. You don't need to be burned out, miserable or in crisis.

Sometimes life is actually pretty damn good. It just may not fit anymore.

- You're thinking about selling the business.
- Retirement is suddenly visible on the horizon.
- You accomplished the thing you spent twenty years chasing—and aren't sure what comes after it.
- You've been offered an opportunity that looks fantastic on paper.
- The mission that defined you is ending.
- Nothing dramatic happened. You simply don't want the next ten years to look exactly like the last ten.

That doesn't mean the last chapter was wrong. It may simply mean you're ready for another one.

THE SUCCESS TRAP

Success gives you something wonderful: options.

It also gives you something considerably more complicated: things to lose.

- Income
- Identity
- Status
- Reputation
- Relationships
- Lifestyle
- Security
- The story you've spent years telling yourself about who you are

So you do what smart, successful people do. You think. You make the spreadsheet. You talk to people you trust. You read another book. You ask AI. You imagine five different futures. You convince yourself of one on Tuesday and talk yourself out of it by Thursday.

How much of your life do you want to spend figuring it out?

I KNOW THIS QUESTION

I didn't create The Next Chapter™ because I figured life out.

I created it because "What's next?" has hit me in the face more than once.

The first time I really understood the question was after I left the Navy.

When I joined the military, something interesting happened. The military gave me three things most people spend a lifetime trying to figure out:

MISSION. PURPOSE. IDENTITY.

My mission was clear. It came through commander's intent. I understood what needed to be accomplished and my role in accomplishing it.

My purpose felt clear too. In very simple terms, I was helping protect people and helping save the world from bad people.

And my identity? That might have been clearest of all. I wore it. My uniform told people who I was. My rank told me where I fit. My unit told me where I belonged.

Then I left the military. Almost overnight: no uniform, no rank, no commander's intent, no institution telling me where I belonged or what mattered next.

WHO AM I WITHOUT ALL OF THAT?

I didn't have a very good answer. So I did what a lot of ambitious people do when they don't know who they are: I started trying to prove it.

WHEN ACHIEVEMENT BECOMES IDENTITY

After college, I chased opportunity. I chased achievement. And I chased money.

I went through 14 different jobs. At the time, I probably would have told you I was ambitious. Looking back, I think something else was happening. I was trying to find an identity.

Maybe the next title would do it. Maybe the next opportunity. Maybe making more money. Maybe building something important. Maybe if I became successful enough, I'd finally feel like I amounted to something.

I had confused what I did with who I was.

And I was horribly wrong.

That confusion didn't only affect my career. It affected my relationships. It affected my marriage.

Because there's an uncomfortable question I've had to confront: How could someone truly know and love me when I wasn't even sure what it meant to be me?

Eventually, my first marriage ended. And there was a particularly brutal irony in that: I had written one of the early books about military marriage—and I hadn't been able to save my own.

Talk about imposter syndrome. Suddenly WHAT'S NEXT? wasn't an interesting intellectual question. It was waiting for me every morning.

AND THEN IT HAPPENED AGAIN

For 15 years, during the highs and lows of my own identity crisis and marriage struggles, I led the nonprofit I founded.

The work gave me extraordinary opportunities. I worked across government agencies, private industry, startups and community organizations. I wrote books. Entered the film world. Executive produced. Hosted a podcast. Spoke. Advised leaders. Built things.

And eventually that chapter ended too.

WHAT'S NEXT?

This time I had considerably more options. I could consult, speak, build another company, work with executives, produce, write, take a job, or start something completely different.

I knew what I could do. That wasn't the problem. I wasn't clear about what I actually wanted to do. Those are very different questions.

THE ANSWER WASN'T ANOTHER JOB

The breakthrough eventually came through my faith and through some serious examination of the life I had built.

I had spent decades answering, "What do you do?" But I hadn't spent nearly enough time answering, "Who are you?"

I AM NOT WHAT I DO.

My job can change. My title can disappear. A company can be sold. A career can end. Children grow up. Relationships change. Money comes and goes. Organizations continue without us.

If my entire identity is attached to those things, what happens when they're gone?

That realization changed the question. Instead of asking, "What should I do next?" I started asking:

Who do I want to be in the life I'm building next?

WHAT DOES AN 8 LOOK LIKE?

If I’m not my title, company, rank, income or accomplishments, I need something else against which to make decisions.

I need a clearer picture of the life I’m actually trying to build. That’s where the 8s come in.

I don’t believe the goal is a perfect life. Perfect is a lousy operating standard. Instead, I use a different target:

AN 8.

On a scale of 1–10, an 8 is strong, achievable and measurable. Not fantasy. Not perfection. Not someone else’s definition of success. Your 8.

MENTALLY	Challenge, curiosity, learning, peace, stress, space and energy. What does mentally strong and engaged look like for you now?
PHYSICALLY	Energy, movement, sleep, strength and health. What allows you to be physically capable of living the life you say you want?
SPIRITUALLY	Faith, purpose, service, gratitude and connection. What grounds you and gives your life meaning beyond achievement?
RELATIONSHIPS	Who matters? How do you want the people closest to you to experience you? What does presence look like now?
FINANCIALLY	What income, security and lifestyle do you actually need? What is enough—and what are you no longer willing to trade simply to make more?

NOW THE DECISIONS GET INTERESTING

Once your 8s become clear, you have something incredibly useful: a decision filter.

HOW DOES THIS DECISION FEED MY 8s?

Suppose you’re offered a job paying 30% more. Financially, maybe it moves you from a 7 to a 9. Great. But what if it requires another 25 nights a year away from home? What happens to your relationship 8? Your physical 8? Your mental 8? Your spiritual 8?

Suddenly we’re no longer asking, “Is this a good opportunity?” We’re asking, “Is this a good opportunity for the life I’m trying to build?”

A decision can look brilliant on a résumé and still be completely wrong for your life.

Your 8s don’t make the decision for you. They help you evaluate it. They turn “I don’t know what I want” into “I know what I’m trying to build.”

There will rarely be a decision that improves all five areas equally. The point is to see the tradeoffs before you make them—to make them consciously, know why you're making them, and decide whether they're worth it.

DON'T FIND YOUR NEXT CHAPTER. ARCHITECT IT.

Most accomplished people don't suffer from a lack of intelligence. You probably don't need someone to tell you what to do. And you certainly don't need another motivational speech about "following your passion."

What you may need is a clearer architecture for making a consequential decision.

What could I do? is different from What should I do? Which is different from What do I want to do? Which is different again from What am I willing to do?

That's where Decision Architecture™ comes in.

CLARITY

What is true now? What matters? What are your 8s?

DECISION

Facts vs. assumptions. Criteria. Tradeoffs. Reality.

DIRECTION

What stays? What changes? Where are you headed—and why?

ACTION

Meaningful moves that create evidence and momentum.

We don't wait for perfect certainty. We create enough clarity to choose a direction, then use action to create new evidence. Because clarity without action eventually becomes another form of avoidance.

THE DECISION IN FRONT OF YOU

At some point, “What’s next?” has to become more specific.

Because most of us aren't actually trying to decide our entire future.

We're trying to resolve a decision.

- Do I sell the business—or keep building?
- Do I step away—or stay involved?
- Do I replace the executive—or give them more time?
- Do I take the opportunity—or turn it down?
- Do I retire—or build something else?
- Do I make the investment—or walk away?
- Do I stay on the path I'm on—or finally admit I want something different?

Or maybe you can't name the decision yet. You simply know something no longer fits.

That's okay too. Sometimes the first decision is figuring out what you're actually deciding.

WHY SMART PEOPLE GET STUCK

If this were an easy decision, you probably would have made it already.

The hardest decisions aren't difficult because there's one obviously good option and one obviously bad one.

They're difficult because several options could work.

And each comes with consequences.

Your CFO may see the numbers. Your attorney sees the risk. Your board sees the company. Your team sees what the decision means for them. Your spouse sees what it means for your life.

Everyone has a perspective. Some have a stake in the outcome.

YOU HAVE TO LIVE WITH THE DECISION.

That's why more advice isn't necessarily the answer. You need a way to get outside the decision long enough to see it clearly.

WORK THE DECISION

DEFINE

What are we actually deciding? Not the symptoms. Not the ten surrounding questions. The decision underneath them.

ESTABLISH THE CRITERIA

What must be true for this decision to work? What actually matters—not what is merely desirable?

EXPOSE THE ASSUMPTIONS

What are you treating as fact that hasn't actually been tested?

MAP THE OPTIONS

What are the legitimate paths? Not every theoretical possibility. The real ones.

PRICE THE TRADEOFFS

What does each choice give you—and what does it require you to give up? Every meaningful yes contains a no.

PRESSURE-TEST THE DIRECTION

Does the choice survive reality—financially, professionally, relationally, and against your 8s?

CHOOSE

At some point, analysis has to become a decision. Not because uncertainty has disappeared. Because you've created enough clarity to choose.

MOVE

Then we act. Not someday. Now.

THE +1

I've learned that big decisions don't always require big first moves. They require the right next move.

THE DECISION What am I deciding?

THE +1 What meaningful action comes next?

THE EVIDENCE What am I trying to learn?

BY WHEN When will I do it?

You don't need the entire path. You need enough clarity to make the next meaningful move.

BRING THE DECISION. LEAVE WITH THE ARCHITECTURE.

There are some decisions you can work through over coffee. Others deserve more.

Not because you're incapable of making them yourself. Quite the opposite. You're probably successful because you've spent years making difficult decisions.

But sometimes you're simply too close to this one.

The consequences are significant. The options are legitimate. The people around you have perspectives. And you've been carrying it long enough.

That's why I created the:

30-DAY DECISION SPRINT™

ONE CONSEQUENTIAL DECISION. 30 DAYS. PRIVATE DECISION ARCHITECTURE.

This isn't a course. It isn't group coaching. It isn't therapy. It isn't an indefinite coaching relationship. And it isn't me telling you what you should do.

We work together. Privately. On the actual decision in front of you.

HOW IT WORKS

WEEK 1 — DEFINE

We identify the real decision. What are you actually trying to resolve? What's at stake? What constraints are real? What criteria must be true for the decision to work?

WEEK 2 — ARCHITECT

We examine the legitimate options. We separate facts from assumptions. We look at the numbers. We identify the tradeoffs. And we determine what evidence is still missing.

WEEK 3 — PRESSURE TEST

Now we challenge the leading direction. Does it survive financial reality? Professional reality? Your relationships? Your 8s? What happens if the assumptions are wrong? What are you unwilling to give up?

WEEK 4 — DECIDE + MOVE

We establish the direction. Document why. Identify the guardrails. And determine the first meaningful moves.

Not perfect certainty. Enough clarity to own the decision and move.

WHAT WE ACTUALLY DO TOGETHER

- A 90-minute Decision Intensive
- Three private Decision Architecture working sessions
- Decision-related access to me between sessions

- Human 10.0™ and Decision Architecture™ tools selected for your situation
- Real-world assumption testing and +1 moves

And throughout the engagement, we build something tangible.

YOUR NEXT CHAPTER BLUEPRINT™

You don't leave with a notebook full of interesting thoughts. You leave with your architecture.

YOUR DECISION — What is actually being decided.

YOUR CRITERIA — What must be true.

YOUR OPTIONS — The legitimate alternatives considered.

YOUR ASSUMPTIONS — What we tested rather than simply accepted.

YOUR TRADEOFFS — What each direction gives—and requires giving up.

YOUR NUMBERS — The financial realities that matter.

YOUR DIRECTION — What you're choosing and why.

YOUR FIRST MOVES — What happens next.

WRITTEN DOWN. YOURS.

The Sprint is designed to resolve one consequential decision and establish an executable direction within 30 days.

That doesn't mean every external outcome happens in 30 days. A company may still need to be sold. A board may need to approve something. Financing may need to close. A job offer may still need to be negotiated. A spouse or business partner may need to be part of what happens next.

The objective isn't to manufacture certainty or rush the outcome.

The objective is to stop allowing the decision itself to remain indefinitely unresolved.

THE DECISION IS YOURS

“I DON'T KNOW EXACTLY WHAT I WANT.”

Good. You don't need to. If you already had complete clarity, you probably wouldn't need this work. We don't begin with “Tell me your perfect future.” We begin with “Tell me what's true right now.” Sometimes identifying the actual decision is the first part of the work.

“I'M NOT READY TO BLOW UP MY LIFE.”

Good. I don't want you to. The objective isn't change for the sake of change. The objective is alignment. Sometimes the decision is stay. Sometimes it's not yet. Sometimes it's go. Sometimes it's realizing what you've already built is exactly where you belong. The goal isn't disruption. The goal is a decision you can stand behind.

“I CAN PROBABLY FIGURE THIS OUT MYSELF.”

You probably can. You're successful for a reason. The better question is: Is continuing to wrestle with this alone the best use of your time and perspective? My job isn't to be smarter than you. It's to notice what you're not noticing, ask the question you haven't asked, challenge the assumption you've stopped questioning, separate fact from story, make the tradeoffs visible, and put architecture around something that has become tangled.

“IS THIS COACHING?”

There may be moments that feel like coaching. But coach doesn't completely describe the role I play. I think of myself as a Decision Architect. An architect doesn't decide what kind of life you should build. An architect helps clarify what you're trying to create, identify the constraints, challenge choices that don't fit the objective and turn an idea into a structure. Your life. Your decision. Your chapter.

PRIVATE. CONFIDENTIAL. NO AGENDA BUT YOURS.

Some decisions can't be worked through freely with your employees, your board, investors—or even the people closest to you. That's part of what makes them difficult.

This is a confidential working relationship. I don't have to live with your decision. I don't benefit from you choosing Option A instead of Option B.

My job is to help you see clearly enough to own the choice yourself.

WHO THIS IS FOR

The 30-Day Decision Sprint is designed for CEOs, founders, business owners and accomplished executives facing a real consequential decision or transition.

There should be something at stake—financially, professionally or personally.

Maybe you have multiple viable options. Maybe you know exactly what the decision is. Maybe something has changed and you haven't yet figured out what needs to be decided.

All three are legitimate places to begin. But there should be a willingness to examine the issue seriously—and move when the direction becomes clear.

WHO THIS IS NOT FOR

This isn't for someone looking for a guru. It isn't therapy or clinical support. It isn't résumé writing. It isn't job placement. It isn't financial, legal or investment advice. And it's probably not for someone who enjoys talking about change but has no intention of doing anything with the answer.

EVENTUALLY, SOMETHING HAS TO MOVE.

THE INVESTMENT

You can spend another six months wrestling with the decision. Sometimes more time really is what a decision requires.

But waiting isn't neutral. It consumes attention. Mental bandwidth. Momentum. Sometimes money. Opportunities remain unexplored. Conversations stay postponed. And the decision keeps running quietly in the background.

WHAT IS IT COSTING ME TO KEEP THIS DECISION OPEN?

THE 30-DAY DECISION SPRINT™

Private Decision Architecture™ • One consequential decision • 30 days

\$5,000

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER 30 DAYS?

The Sprint stands on its own. There is no required next program. No automatic retainer. No manufactured dependency.

You leave with your direction and your Next Chapter Blueprint™.

But sometimes resolving one consequential decision exposes the next.

For select clients who want me available as new opportunities, challenges and consequential decisions emerge, I maintain a limited number of ongoing:

CEO DECISION ADVISORY

Private. Ongoing. By invitation.

We don't need to decide that now.

First, let's resolve the decision in front of you.

ONE LAST THOUGHT

You don't need a crisis to reconsider what comes next. You don't have to throw away everything you've built. You don't need to have the answer before you begin. And you certainly don't need to become someone else.

But there are some questions worth answering deliberately:

- What matters now?
- What does an 8 look like across the five areas of my life?

- What have I outgrown?
- What am I holding onto because it still matters—and what am I holding onto simply because it took a long time to build?
- What am I still trying to prove?
- What would I choose if I didn't need to prove it anymore?
- What decision am I actually avoiding?
- Which things am I treating as facts that are really assumptions?
- What am I unwilling to give up?
- How does the decision in front of me feed my 8s?

WHAT IS THE COST OF NOT DECIDING?

You don't have to see the entire path. You need enough clarity to choose the next move.

WHAT'S NEXT?

IF YOU FOUND YOURSELF SOMEWHERE IN THESE PAGES, THAT'S PROBABLY WORTH PAYING ATTENTION TO.

I KNOW THERE'S A REAL DECISION HERE.

You have something consequential in front of you and you're ready to stop circling it.

TALK THROUGH THE DECISION →

I'M STILL TRYING TO GET CLEAR.

Something has changed, but you're not yet sure where you're stuck.

TAKE THE 3-MINUTE DECISION CLARITY ASSESSMENT →

MICHAEL SCHINDLER

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Better decisions. Stronger humans. What's next?